

OUTLAW

The Great Canyon Crossing

A Wild Horse Adventure

StorySprout Press

*For Samantha who embodies the strength and
determination of Outlaw, along with his stubborn ways.
May you always run wild and free.*

Outlaw: The Great Canyon Crossing
Outlaw Wild Horse Series, Book 1

Published by StorySprout Press

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Contents

Meet the Herd

Character Introductions

Chapter 1: The First Frost

Chapter 2: The High Path

Chapter 3: Shadow's Challenge

Chapter 4: Into the Depths

Chapter 5: The Ledge of Fear

Chapter 6: The Divided Path

Chapter 7: The Roar of the Water

Chapter 8: The Hero's Leap

Chapter 9: The Final Ascent

Chapter 10: The Hidden Valley

Chapter 11: The Winter King

About the Author

Meet the Herd

Outlaw — A magnificent black stallion with a midnight coat and a brave heart. The leader of the herd.

Sunny — A wise golden palomino mare who has seen many winters. Outlaw's most trusted friend.

Swift — A young bay colt full of energy and excitement. Always ready for adventure.

Bramble — A sturdy grey gelding with steady feet and a calm soul. Keeps watch at the rear.

Clover — A curious sorrel filly who loves to explore the world around her.

Shadow — A powerful black-and-white paint stallion with a mean streak -- but a hidden heart.

Chapter 1

Chapter 1: The First Frost

* * *

The golden sun was dipping low over the horizon, painting the sky in streaks of purple and orange. The tall prairie grass, once green and lush, was now a brittle shade of brown. Outlaw stood alone on the highest point of a rocky ridge. He was a magnificent stallion, his coat as dark as a midnight sky and his muscles rippling beneath his skin. His long, black mane snapped like a whip in the biting wind.

Outlaw turned his gaze toward the north. He didn't need a calendar to know that the seasons were changing. He could feel it in the stiffness of his joints and the way the air tasted like iron. He snorted loudly, a thick cloud of white steam erupting from his nostrils. Winter was coming, and it was coming fast.



Deep in his chest, Outlaw felt a rumble of worry. This part of the plains offered no protection from the howling blizzards that would soon sweep across the land. The herd needed to reach the Hidden Valley. It was a secret place, tucked away behind the high peaks, where the grass stayed sweet and the trees blocked the worst of the snow. But to get there, they had to cross the Painted Canyons place of great beauty and even greater danger.

"Is it time, Outlaw?" a soft, steady voice asked from behind him.

Outlaw didn't need to turn around to know it was Sunny. She was a beautiful palomino mare with a coat the color of a summer morning. As the oldest member of the herd, she

had seen many winters. She was wise, and Outlaw trusted her more than anyone else.

"Yes, Sunny," Outlaw replied, his voice a low nicker. "The first frost will settle on the grass tonight. We cannot wait any longer. We must begin the journey at dawn."

Just then, a blur of brown fur came charging up the ridge. It was Swift, a young bay colt who seemed to have more energy than the rest of the herd combined. He skidded to a halt next to Outlaw, his tail held high.

"Are we going? Are we finally going to the mountains?" Swift asked, his eyes wide with excitement. "I'm ready! I can run faster than the wind!"

Outlaw gave the colt a gentle nudge with his nose. "It is not just about running, Swift. This will be a long, hard walk. You must listen to Sunny and stay close to the middle of the herd. The trails in the canyon are very narrow."



Swift bucked once, showing off his strong legs. "I'll be careful, Outlaw! I promise!"

As the sun disappeared, the temperature plummeted. The horses gathered at the base of the ridge, huddling together for warmth. Outlaw stood on the edge of the group, his ears pricked for the sound of predators. He watched the stars pop out one by one in the clear, cold sky. By midnight, the ground was covered in a thin, sparkling layer of frost.

Outlaw didn't sleep. He watched the northern sky, where heavy, dark clouds were already beginning to pile up. The Great Canyon Crossing was about to begin, and he knew he had to be a strong leader to keep them all safe.



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Chapter 2

Chapter 2: The High Path

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At the first light of dawn, the herd was moving. Outlaw took his place at the front, his hooves thudding rhythmically against the frozen earth. Behind him followed the others: Sunny, Swift, and the rest of the families. Bramble, a sturdy grey gelding, kept a watchful eye on the rear. Bramble wasn't fast, but he was as steady as a rock and knew how to find water even in the driest creek beds.

Clover, a young sorrel filly, walked near Sunny. She was a curious horse who loved to stop and sniff the sagebrush or watch a hawk circling overhead.

"Keep moving, Clover," Sunny urged gently. "We have many miles to cover today."

The wind grew stronger as they approached the foothills. The sky was a dull, flat grey, and the air felt heavy. Outlaw's instincts told him that a major storm was brewing. If they took the low trail around the canyon, it would take them three days. The snow would surely trap them.

"The Painted Canyon is just ahead," Bramble called out, trotting up to join Outlaw. "But the main trail is flooded from the autumn rains. It will be slow going."

Outlaw looked up at the towering red cliffs. High above, a narrow path wound its way through the highest ridges. It was a shortcut, but it was famous for being treacherous.

"We will take the high path," Outlaw decided, his voice firm.

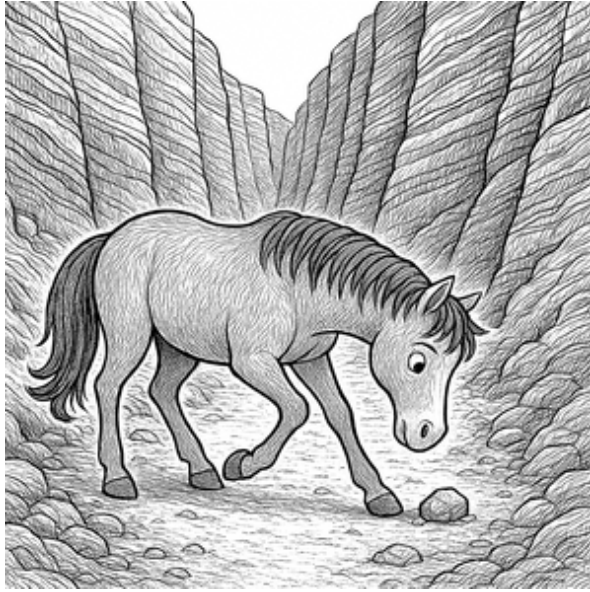
"The high path?" Clover whispered, looking up at the dizzying heights. "But it's so skinny!"

"It is the only way to beat the snow," Outlaw said. "If we stay on the plains or take the low road, the blizzard will catch us. We must reach the canyon floor before the storm hits."



The herd reached the entrance to the canyon. The walls were spectacular, striped with layers of crimson, orange, and bright yellow. In the summer, it was a place of wonder. Now, in the fading light, it looked like a giant trap. The trail was little more than a shelf of rock clinging to the side of the mountain.

"One at a time," Outlaw commanded. "Bramble, you take the lead for a moment. You have the steadiest feet. I will stay at the back to make sure no one slips."



The horses began the descent. It was terrifying work. Every time a hoof shifted, a shower of pebbles would tumble hundreds of feet down into the shadows below. Swift stayed glued to Sunny's side, his breath coming in short, nervous gasps. Outlaw watched every movement, his heart racing. He felt the wind pushing against his side, trying to knock him off balance. He dug his hooves in deep, refusing to be moved.

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Chapter 3

Chapter 3: Shadow's Challenge

* * *

By midday, the herd was deep within the heart of the Painted Canyon. The trail had become even narrower, and the wind was whistling through the rock formations like a ghostly flute. Suddenly, a large stallion forced his way past Sunny and Swift, nearly knocking the young colt into the rock wall.

It was Shadow. He was a black-and-white paint stallion with a powerful build and a mean streak. He had always wanted to be the leader, and he never missed a chance to tell Outlaw that he was doing a bad job.

"Stop!" Shadow bellowed. The sound was so loud that a nearby mountain goat scrambled away in fear.

Outlaw pushed his way forward until he was nose-to-nose with Shadow. "What are you doing, Shadow? You almost hurt the foal."

"This path is a death trap!" Shadow shouted, his eyes rolling back to show the whites. "Look at the horses! They are shaking with fear. Your 'shortcut' is going to get us all killed."

Outlaw looked back. It was true that the horses were tired and scared. But he also looked at the sky. The clouds were now a bruised purple color, and the first few flakes of snow were swirling in the air.

"We cannot go back, Shadow," Outlaw said calmly. "We are more than halfway through. Turning around now would take us right into the teeth of the storm. Here, at least, the canyon walls give us some shelter from the wind."

"I don't care about your 'feelings' about the weather!" Shadow hissed, baring his teeth. "I think you just like leading us into danger so you can feel important. I'm a stronger stallion than you. I should be the one making the decisions."



The rest of the herd watched in silence. Sunny stepped forward, her golden coat standing out against the red rock. "Shadow, this is not the time for a fight. We need to keep moving."

"Stay out of this, old mare!" Shadow snapped. He turned back to the herd. "Who is with me? We can go back to the lowlands. We can find a cave and wait out the storm there. Who wants to follow a leader who puts foals on a cliff edge?"

For a moment, no one moved. A few of the younger horses looked toward the back of the trail, thinking of the flat, safe ground they had left behind. But then, Bramble stepped up next to Outlaw. Then Sunny. Then Clover and Swift.

"We stay with Outlaw," Bramble said firmly.

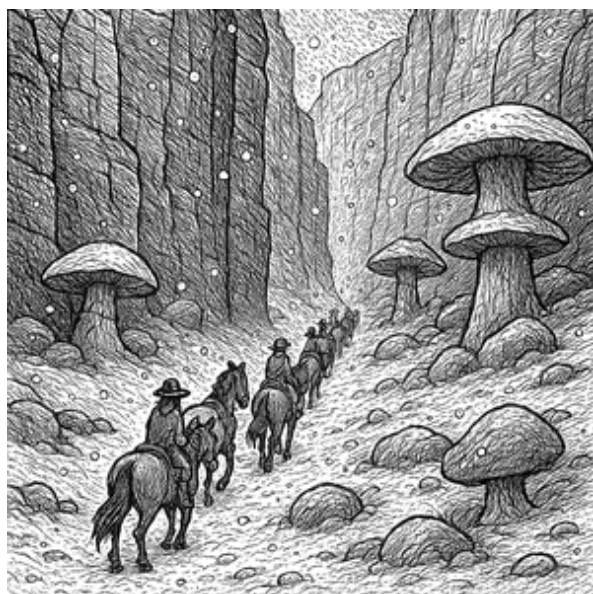
Shadow's face twisted with rage. He was alone. Even his closest friends in the herd wouldn't follow him back into the storm.

"Fine," Shadow muttered, stepping back into the line. "But when the rocks start to crumble, don't expect me to save you."



Outlaw felt a chill that had nothing to do with the wind. A divided herd was a weak herd. He had to prove to them and to Shadow that he could get them through this.

"Keep your heads down and watch the horse in front of you," Outlaw called out. "We are almost to the ledge crossing. Once we pass that, it's a straight shot to the valley floor. Let's move!"



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Chapter 4

Chapter 4: Into the Depths

* * *

The herd descended deeper into the Painted Canyon. The walls rose up on either side like giant, sleeping monsters. The air down here was different. It didn't smell like the open plains. It smelled of damp earth and old stone. The sound of their hooves changed, too. On the ridge, it had been a sharp *clack*. Now, it was a dull *thump* as they stepped onto the sandy floor of the canyon.

"We made it down!" Swift cried, his voice bouncing off the rocks. He did a little hop, kick-starting his back legs.

"Not yet, little one," Sunny said, her voice calm but serious. "We are at the bottom, but the canyon is long. We still have many miles to walk before we find the exit."

Outlaw led them toward a small stream that ran through the center of the canyon. The water was clear and cold. The horses stopped for a quick drink. Outlaw kept his eyes moving. He looked at the high walls. He looked for mountain lions or coyotes. He also looked for the way out.

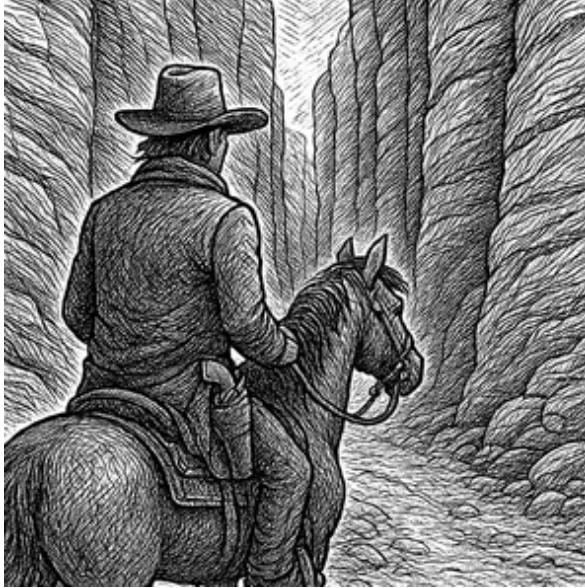


"The Painted Canyon is beautiful," Clover said, looking at the purple flowers that grew in the cracks of the rocks. "I've never seen colors like this."

"Focus on the trail, Clover," Outlaw said. He pointed his ears toward the front. "The wind is picking up again. We need to reach the narrows before it gets too dark."

The "narrows" was the tightest part of the canyon. The walls there were so close together that a horse could almost

touch both sides at once. It was the only way to reach the Hidden Valley, but it was also the most dangerous part of the trip. If it rained, the narrows would fill with water in seconds.



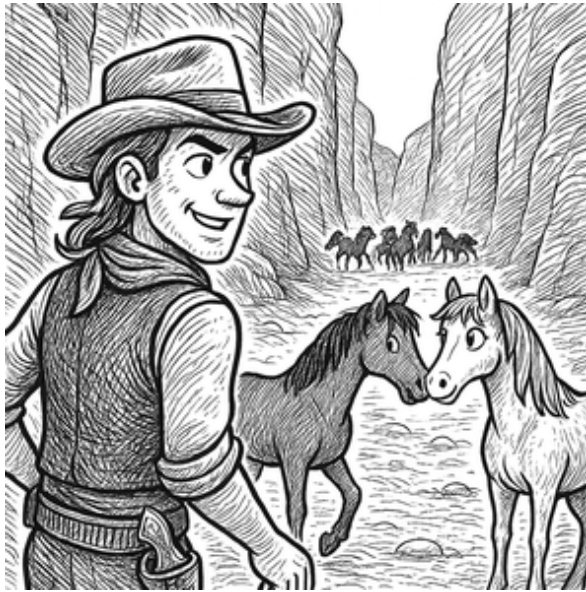
Shadow walked near the back of the herd. He was still grumbling to any horse who would listen. "He's leading us into a tunnel," Shadow whispered to a young mare named Daisy. "If the sky opens up, we will be trapped like rats."

Daisy looked up at the thin strip of grey sky far above. She shivered. "Do you really think so, Shadow?"

"I know so," Shadow said, his eyes gleaming. "But don't worry. I have a plan if things go wrong."

Outlaw didn't hear Shadow's words, but he saw the way the other horses were looking at each other. He knew he had to keep their spirits up.

"We are doing well!" Outlaw called out, his voice strong. "The Hidden Valley is just on the other side of those walls. Imagine the warm sun and the sweet grass. We are almost there!"



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Chapter 5

Chapter 5: The Ledge of Fear

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The trail began to rise again. The canyon floor was blocked by a massive pile of fallen rocks. To get past them, the horses had to climb onto a narrow ledge that hugged the eastern wall. This ledge was even smaller than the one they had used to enter the canyon.

"Stay single file," Bramble commanded. He was at the front now because he was the best at finding solid footing. "And whatever you do, don't look over the edge."

Swift was trembling. His legs felt like jelly. "I... I can't do it, Sunny," he whispered.

Sunny nudged him gently with her shoulder. "Yes, you can, Swift. You are a wild horse. You have the blood of leaders in you. Just look at my tail and follow the rhythm of my

steps."



The wind began to howl through the narrows. It sounded like a giant screaming. It pushed against the horses, trying to shove them off the ledge. Outlaw stayed at the very back, his dark coat now dusted with white snow. The storm had finally caught up to them.

Suddenly, a loud *CRACK* echoed through the canyon. A large branch from a pine tree high above had snapped and was falling straight toward the herd.

"Watch out!" Outlaw screamed.

The branch crashed onto the ledge right in front of Shadow. He reared up, his hooves flailing in the air.

"It's falling! The mountain is falling!" Shadow panicked. He pushed backward, nearly knocking Daisy off the ledge.

"Shadow, stay calm!" Outlaw barked. "It was just a branch. Get down!"



Shadow lowered his feet, but his eyes were wide with terror. He was breathing hard. The rest of the herd was frozen, too scared to move. The snow was falling faster now, making the ledge slippery.

"Bramble, move!" Outlaw shouted. "We can't stay here!"

Slowly, the line of horses began to move again. Every step was a battle against the wind and the ice. Outlaw watched Shadow closely. The black-and-white horse was no longer acting like a leader. He was acting like a scared colt.

Finally, the ledge widened into a small plateau. The horses scrambled onto the flat ground, gasping for air. They were safe from the heights, but they were now in the middle of a blizzard.



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Chapter 6

Chapter 6: The Divided Path

* * *

The snow was so thick that Outlaw could barely see his own tail. The herd was gathered in a tight circle on the plateau. They were cold and exhausted.

"We need to find shelter," Sunny said. Her golden coat was now hidden under a layer of white. "The foals cannot handle this cold for much longer."

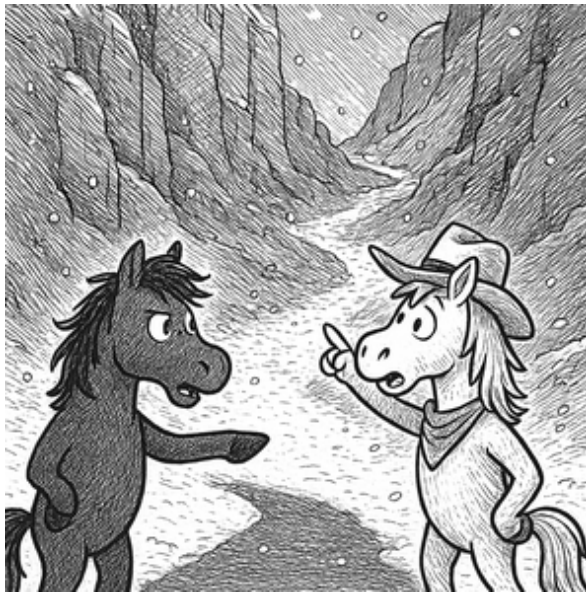
Outlaw looked around. In the dim light, he saw two openings in the canyon wall. One was a steep, rocky trail that led upward. The other was a lower path that followed the canyon floor.

"The high path leads to the exit," Outlaw said. "The lower path is a dead end. We must go up."

"No!" Shadow shouted. He had found his voice again. "Look at that lower path. It's covered in soft sand. It will be warm down there. We can find a cave and wait."

"Shadow, the floor of the canyon is dangerous in a storm," Outlaw warned. "If it rains instead of snows, that path will become a river."

"It's not raining, Outlaw! It's snowing!" Shadow pointed his hoof at the lower path. "Who wants to climb another mountain in a blizzard? Follow me to the sand!"



To Outlaw's horror, three of the younger horses began to walk toward Shadow. They were too tired to think clearly. They just wanted to stop climbing.

"Stop!" Outlaw commanded, his voice like thunder. "I am your leader. I am telling you that the lower path is a trap."

"You aren't a leader!" Shadow spat. "You're a tyrant. You're going to kill us with your 'shortcuts' and your 'high paths.' Come on, Daisy! Come on, Jax!"

Shadow led his small group toward the lower path. Outlaw wanted to run after them and force them back, but he couldn't leave the rest of the herd. Sunny, Swift, Bramble, and Clover were still looking to him for direction.



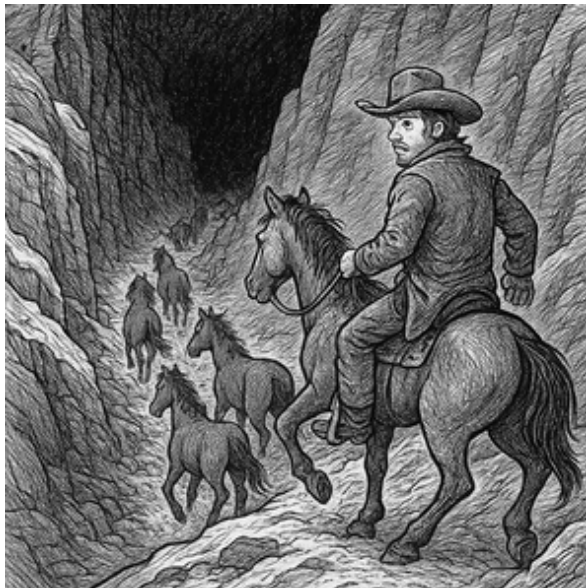
"Let them go," Bramble said softly. "We have to save who we can."

Outlaw's heart felt like it was being torn in two. He had failed. A part of his herd was gone. But he couldn't give up.

He had to get the others to safety.

"We climb," Outlaw said, his voice cracking with emotion.

"Move out."



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Chapter 7

Chapter 7: The Roar of the Water

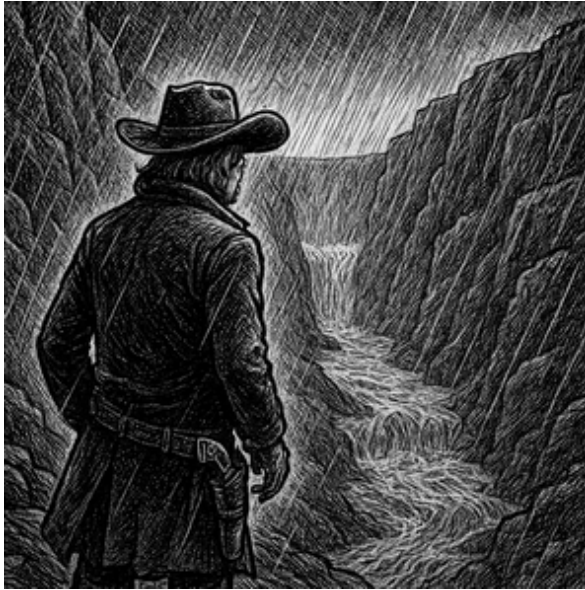
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The climb was slow and painful. Outlaw, Sunny, Bramble, Clover, and Swift moved like ghosts through the white swirl of the blizzard. But as they climbed higher, the air began to change. The sharp, biting cold of the snow turned into a heavy, damp heat. The snowflakes became thick, fat drops of rain.

"It's raining!" Clover cried, her mane soaking wet. "The snow is melting!"

Outlaw stopped and looked down. He could no longer see Shadow or the other horses. But he could hear something. It wasn't the wind. It was a low, deep rumble, like a thousand drums beating at once.

"Flash flood!" Bramble shouted, his ears pinned back. "The rain is melting the snow on the peaks. The water is coming down the canyon!"



A wall of brown, muddy water roared past the bottom of the trail they had just left. It carried logs, rocks, and bushes. It was a terrifying force of nature.

"Shadow!" Swift screamed. "Shadow is down there!"

Outlaw looked at the lower path. It was completely gone. In its place was a churning river of mud. He saw a flash of black-and-white fur near a large boulder that was sticking out of the water. It was Shadow! He was standing on a tiny piece of rock, and the water was rising fast. Next to him were Daisy and Jax, huddled together and shaking.

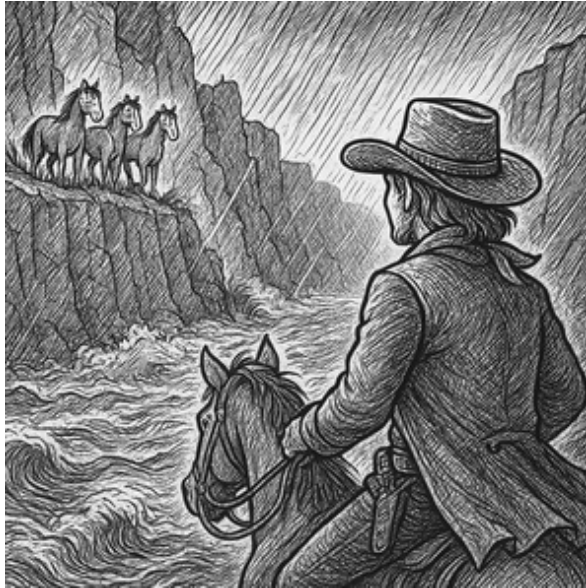
"They're trapped!" Sunny cried. "The water will cover that rock in minutes!"

Outlaw didn't think. He didn't hesitate. He knew Shadow had been mean. He knew Shadow had challenged him. But Shadow was still part of the herd. And Daisy and Jax were innocent.

"Bramble, take the others to the high ledge!" Outlaw ordered. "I'm going down."

"Outlaw, no! It's too dangerous!" Sunny pleaded.

"I am the leader," Outlaw said, his eyes flashing with determination. "I don't leave anyone behind."



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Chapter 8

Chapter 8: The Hero's Leap

* * *

Outlaw scrambled down the slippery rocks. The rain was blinding, and the roar of the water was deafening. He reached the edge of the new river. The current was fast and strong.

"Shadow! Jump!" Outlaw yelled.

Shadow looked at the water and then at Outlaw. He was paralyzed with fear. "I can't! The water is too fast!"

"You have to!" Outlaw barked. "Daisy, you first! Aim for the flat rock near me!"

Daisy took a deep breath and leaped. She splashed into the water, but Outlaw reached out and grabbed her mane with his teeth, pulling her toward the shore. Jax followed, and

Outlaw helped him up as well.

But Shadow was heavier. And the rock he was on was starting to crumble.

"Shadow, now!" Outlaw screamed.

The rock gave way. Shadow tumbled into the freezing, muddy water. He vanished beneath the surface.

"No!" Swift cried from the high trail.



Outlaw didn't wait. He dove into the river. The cold water hit him like a wall of ice. He struggled against the current, his powerful legs kicking hard. He saw Shadow's head pop up for a second, then go under again.

Outlaw swam toward the spot. He felt Shadow's heavy body bump against his side. Outlaw dived down, pushed his shoulder under Shadow, and forced him back to the surface. With every ounce of his strength, Outlaw fought the river. He pushed Shadow toward the bank where Daisy and Jax were waiting.



Finally, Outlaw felt his hooves touch solid ground. He gave one last, giant shove, sending Shadow onto the mud. Outlaw dragged himself out after him, collapsing on the grass. He was shivering, and his lungs burned, but he was alive. And so was Shadow.

Shadow looked at Outlaw. There was no anger in his eyes now. Only shame and gratitude. "You... you saved me," he

whispered.

"We are a herd," Outlaw said, gasping for air. "We save each other."

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Chapter 9

Chapter 9: The Final Ascent

* * *

The rain began to slow, but the danger wasn't over. The water was still high, and the trail up the mountain was slick with mud. The entire herd was back together, but they were weak and cold.

"We have to get out of the canyon," Bramble said. "The walls could still slide."

Outlaw stood up, his legs shaking. He looked at the steep trail that led to the top of the cliffs. It was the hardest part of the journey.

"I'll go first," Shadow said. Everyone looked at him in surprise. "I was wrong, Outlaw. I was selfish. Let me help. I am strong, and I can test the mud for the foals."

Outlaw nodded. "Together, then."

Shadow took the lead, carefully choosing the safest spots for his hooves. Outlaw stayed at the back, encouraging the tired horses. Swift and Clover walked between Sunny and Daisy, their heads low but their spirits returning.



The climb felt like it lasted forever. The sun had long since set, and the only light came from the moon reflecting off the wet rocks. Every step was an effort. Swift stumbled once, and Sunny was there to catch him. Daisy slipped, and Bramble pushed her back up.

"I see it!" Clover cried suddenly. "I see the top!"

The horses gave one last push. They scrambled over the final ridge and stood on the flat ground above the Painted

Canyon.



They looked out across the land. On the other side of the mountain, the clouds had parted. Below them lay a beautiful, green valley. It was the Hidden Valley. It was filled with tall pine trees and a sparkling lake. And there, in the moonlight, they could see the grass was still green and thick.

"We made it," Outlaw whispered.

"We made it because of you," Sunny said, resting her head on his shoulder.

Shadow stepped forward and bowed his head to Outlaw. "You are the true leader, Outlaw. I will follow you anywhere."



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Chapter 10

Chapter 10: The Hidden Valley

* * *

The Hidden Valley was even more beautiful than the stories said. The grass was deep and sweet, not brittle like the grass on the plains. The trees were thick with needles that stayed green all year. A large, blue lake sat in the middle of the valley, and the water was calm.

"Look at the grass!" Swift cried, taking a big bite. "It tastes like honey!"

The horses spent the next few days resting and eating. Their coats began to look shiny again. The foals played by the edge of the lake, splashing each other with water. Clover found a patch of late-blooming mountain flowers and showed them to everyone.



While the others rested, Outlaw and Shadow walked the perimeter of the valley. They looked for the best places to hide from the wind. They found a large cave behind a waterfall that would keep the whole herd dry.

"This is a good place, Outlaw," Shadow said. He was much quieter now. "I'm sorry for what I said in the canyon. I was scared, and I let my fear make me mean."

Outlaw stopped and looked at the black-and-white stallion. "Fear is a powerful thing, Shadow. It can make a horse do things they wouldn't normally do. But a leader has to look past the fear. You are strong. We need that strength to protect the herd this winter."

Shadow nodded. "I will use my strength for the herd from now on. I promise."



As they walked, they met a family of mountain goats. The goats were used to the horses and didn't run away. One old goat with long, curved horns told them about a path to a salt lick nearby.

"The winter will be long," the goat said. "But this valley has always kept us safe."

Outlaw felt a sense of peace. He had led his family through the darkness and into the light. He had lost part of the herd for a moment, but he had brought them back. He was no longer just a stallion with a dark coat. He was a true leader.



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Chapter 11

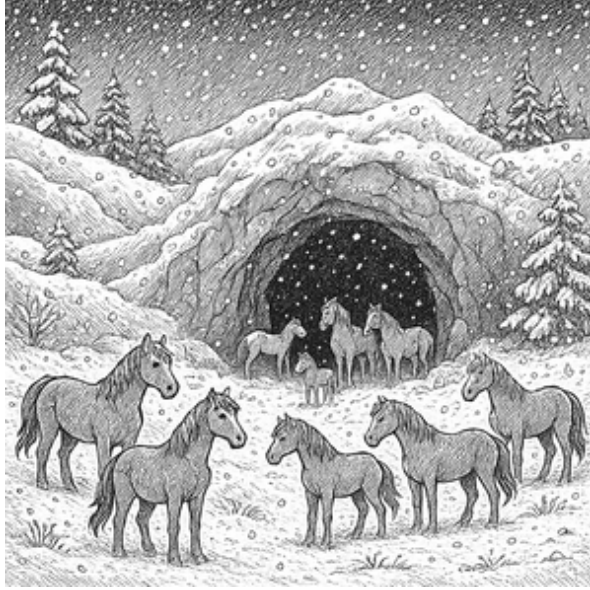
Chapter 11: The Winter King

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A week later, the sky turned a very bright white. The wind died down completely. The air was silent. Then, the first real snowflake of winter drifted down from the sky. It landed right on Outlaw's nose.

"It's here," Outlaw called out.

The herd gathered near the cave by the waterfall. They weren't scared this time. They had plenty of food in their bellies and a warm place to sleep. They watched as the valley began to turn white.



Swift ran out into the snow and tried to catch the flakes on his tongue. "It's like cold stars!" he laughed.

Sunny stood next to Outlaw, her golden coat shimmering against the white snow. "You did it, Outlaw. We are safe."

"We did it together," Outlaw corrected her. He looked at Bramble, who was watching the horizon. He looked at Shadow, who was helping a young mare into the cave. He looked at Clover, who was sharing her grass with a small rabbit.

As the snow got deeper, Outlaw stood at the entrance of the cave. He looked out over his kingdom. The Painted Canyon was far away now. The danger was behind them. Ahead was a season of rest and a new beginning.

Outlaw let out a long, happy whinny. It echoed through the valley and up into the mountains. He was the King of the Wild, and his herd was home.



About the Author

StorySprout Press creates charming, adventurous chapter books for young readers who love animals, nature, and epic journeys. The Outlaw Wild Horse Series was inspired by the wild mustangs of the American West -- their freedom, their courage, and their unbreakable spirit.

Coming soon: Outlaw Book 2 — The Secret of the Silver Canyon